

comparison tables included in the *Digit* CD with this issue.

BUDGET BUDDIES

Notebook prices have fallen steadily over the past 12 months, resulting in a new target audience. The 'Budget' category comprises notebooks that sell for around Rs 50,000, which may be the price point that will encourage their mass adoption.

Eight models fit into this category—one each from IBM, Mercury and Zenith, two from Wipro and three from ACi. The prices ranged from as low as Rs 31,000 to close to Rs 57,000.

Features

As expected, most laptops here ran on desktop hardware. There were some exceptions though—ACi managed to include a Centrino-based notebook, which promises decent features and a good battery life without compromising much on performance. The ACi's Ethos V ran on VIA's C3 processor while Zenith's Performer model integrated an 800 FSB processor. IBM and Wipro opted for Intel's Celeron processors to power their notebooks, while the others ran on Intel Pentium 4 processors.

All notebooks came with at least 256 MB of RAM, making it easy for users to opt for Windows XP. The IBM and ACi Ethos V models had a 14-inch TFT display, which should suffice for most. If you are looking for more, the others deliver. The IBM R40e, the Wipro Notebooks

and the Zenith Performer have the best displays in this category.

All the laptops had a minimum of two USB ports, with the Zenith One-up model boasting of six. Apart from the IBM, Zenith and ACi Ethos, all others had a Firewire port. All the notebooks, without exception, had an Ethernet port.

Hard disk capacities vary the most, and this segment saw a variation of 20 GB to 60 GB. With increasing application sizes of today, 20 GB is too little for a notebook; a decent music collection or movies can rake out GBs of space leaving little space for the OS and applications, not to mention your mail folder. The ideal proposition seems to be a 40 GB hard drive, and Zenith and ACi get full marks for their generosity. CD-ROM drives seem to be a popular choice with most laptops. IBM, Zenith and Mercury opted for a combination drive, and scored over the competition.

Usability

Nothing comes close to IBM's R40e. It sports the best finish of them all, and its ruggedness personified. All other models had similar build qualities, but were nowhere close to being as rugged as the IBM.

The ACi Ethos model's build quality feels weak, but at this low a price you can't really complain.

Don't be fooled by its looks though—this notebook tackled most of our tests better than the competition.

